

Orchestral forms

Many orchestral works of music are written in a specific form that is particular to a genre or time period. The structural organization within musical works helps the listener make sense of the piece.

SEE ALSO

◀ 30–31 Time signatures

◀ 44–45 Tempo

◀ 164–165 Theme and variations

The orchestra

184–185 ▶

Symphonies

Large-scale orchestral pieces are called symphonies. Traditional symphonic forms date from the Classical period, and usually feature a four-movement architecture. Each movement is formally structured and, although separated from the others by a pause, has a strong relationship with the entire symphony.

▽ Four-movement form

Later composers still favored the typical four-movement symphony structure, but expanded upon it by adding movements, using different forms, or unifying their work.

I

Fast tempo
(in sonata form)

II

Slow tempo
(in ABA form)

III

Medium to Fast tempo
(in dance form)

IV

Fast tempo
(rondo form)

LOOKING CLOSER

Haydn's *Symphony No. 88 in G Major*

An energetic, optimistic piece in the Classical four-movement architecture, Haydn's *Symphony No. 88 in G Major* (1787) illustrates his creativity while working within strict Classical forms. The first movement is a sonata form, followed by a graceful theme and variations. The third movement is a rustic, dance-like minuet and trio, and the last a rondo, with the surprising insertion of a delightful canon in the middle.

Adagio-Allegro
(sonata form)

I

◀ First movement

A short, stately introduction in triple meter, followed by a lively duple meter Allegro in sonata form.

Largo
(theme and variations)

II

◀ Second movement

Solo oboe and cello present a legato theme in D Major, triple meter, followed by six variations.

“As **conductor** of an orchestra I could **make experiments...** and was thus in a position to **improve, alter, make additions or omissions, and be as bold** as I pleased.”
Franz Joseph Haydn

Rondo

A rondo, or rondeau, consists of the same theme (A) repeatedly inserted between new material. Many, but not all, Classical rondos are fast and vivacious, using folk themes, and featured as the last movement in the symphony form.

▽ Rondo form

Rondos can be extended by adding new sections, as long as the A section is interspersed throughout. Rondos are often symmetrical, in an overall ABA form.

a	b	a	c	a	b	a
Theme 1	Theme 2	Theme 1	Theme 3	Theme 1	Theme 2	Theme 1
A			B	A		